

EMPTY3

There was once a time when songs existed as downloadable files, when voracious music consumers hoarded files and showed off their "collections". Sadly, that time has since passed. With the rise of streaming music, this article laments the loss of the ever popular file format - the MP3. <http://dgit.in/OoJOSM>

THE PC IS NOT GOING AWAY

Intel CEO Paul Otellini has focused on pushing Intel beyond the PC. In this interview he talks about the high-stakes chip-making game and the company's push into mobile devices. <http://dgit.in/R80Jcl>

APPLE'S BIGGEST MARKETING SECRET

Have you noticed how Apple doesn't really engage in much advertising? Marketing chief Phil Schiller testified recently that the company relies on rave reviews in the media and product placement in movies and TV shows. Mactards rejoice? <http://dgit.in/PvDgB6>

HOW THE INTERNET IS RESHAPING CHINA

China's internet industry is at a fascinating juncture, emerging from the shadows of its copycat past and catapulting itself into a mobile future, one in which it will likely innovate in parallel alongside the best from Silicon Valley. Read more: <http://dgit.in/QNeVW9>

SHORTS

Browser Wars

You can hardly go wrong when choosing a browser these days, but that doesn't mean you shouldn't consider each one's unique features and properties to guide your choice

- By Michael Muchmore



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Web browsers just refuse to sit still. They just keep evolving to offer new speed and standards support, all moving towards the ultimate goal—enabling websites to do everything that native applications can. Case in point? The HTML5 getUserMedia draft specification. This new spec allows a webpage to access a user's webcam and microphone, dispensing with the need for a plugin such as Adobe Flash or Microsoft SilverLight to achieve this feat.

Opera 12 debuted this streaming media capability, with Google Chrome following quickly on its heels (Google is the driving force behind the WebRTC, or real-time communications, of which getUserMedia is a part). Opera's exploding camera demo gives you an idea of the potential of getUserMedia. It is still just a working draft, and competing browser makers will want to implement it in differing ways, but in the end, it's clearly coming.

In order to create app-like websites, however, browsers need not just the functions available to installed apps, but also need to equal the speed that straight-to-the-metal apps can achieve. A concept introduced by Microsoft with Internet Explorer 9 was to use the PC's graphics processor to speed up screen drawing and other activities. This technique

takes advantage of a PC's hardware to practically eliminate any advantage of native apps.

It's an idea that's been taken on by all of the major browser makers, at varying rates. Firefox has pretty much equaled IE9 here, and Chrome isn't far behind. Opera's maker has said that its goal is to hardware accelerate the whole browser's functioning, not just webpage rendering. Again, hardware acceleration isn't something that most of today's websites will benefit from. But those of tomorrow? Definitely.

So what about today? What do you want in a Web browser? You want it to be fast, able to correctly present any website you throw at it, and get out of the way. All of the current crop of software comes close to achieving this goal, while a couple of the lesser known players, Opera and Maxthon, add unique extras on top of this: Opera offers Turbo to speed up slow connections and a built-in BitTorrent client, and Maxthon offers screen and video capture, along with a raft of other power-browsing tools.

For a look at how each of today's top Web browsers for Windows stacks up in speed, new standards support, and interface sleekness, delve into the short reviews linked below. (Follow the link at the end for in-depth reviews)

Chrome 21



Chrome Instant means your Web page is ready to read before you finish typing the

address. This, its speed and minimalist design have deservedly been attracting more and more users to the browser. Leading HTML5 support means it will be ready for the future, application-like Web, and hardware acceleration makes Chrome



a speed maven at any task. Hardware acceleration adds even more speed, but Google still hasn't implemented Do Not Track privacy protection, which every other browser here supports.

Firefox 14



Firefox versions keep coming at a fast clip, now that Mozilla hews to a Chrome-like rapid release schedule. These frequent versions haven't brought the kind of earth-shattering changes we used to see in new full-number Firefox updates, but the development teams have tackled issues of importance to a lot of Web users—startup time,